On 9 September 1981 Lala Jagat Narain, proprietor of a chain of newspapers published from Jalandhar, was shot dead near Ludhiana. Jagat Narain's influential daily *Punjab Kesari* had been critical of Bhindranwale, and Narain, who had been present at the clash between the Sikhs and Nirankaris, had testified in court against Bhindranwale. *Punjab Kesari* was accused of taking a pro-Nirankari stand. According to Mark Tully and Satish Jacob, 'Narain's partisan attitude was typical. In fact, the whole of the Punjab press was divided on communal lines.' [4]

On the day Lala Jagat Narain was killed, Bhindranwale was on a preaching mission at village Chando Kalan in Hisar district in Haryana. He, along with two associates, was named in the FIR filed after the murder. A Punjab police team headed by Deputy Inspector General (DIG) of police D.S. Mangat, was sent with warrants to Chando Kalan under instructions from Chief Minister Darbara Singh to arrest Bhindranwale. Tipped off suitably, Bhindranwale had already left Chando Kalan with some of his supporters and had headed for his headquarters, Gurudwara Darshan Prakash, Chowk Mehta.

He travelled over 300 km through Haryana and Punjab and reached Chowk Mehta in the night of 13-14 September 1981. According to Kuldip Nayar, Zail Singh himself telephoned Haryana chief minister Bhajan Lal and told him not to arrest Bhindranwale and not get involved in the case. 'A senior police officer told Satish Jacob that the Haryana chief minister went as far as to send an official car to Chando Kalan to drive Bhindranwale back to his gurudwara.' [5]

My batchmate Diwakar Das Gupta (IPS 1964 Madhya Pradesh), who was DIG at BSF headquarters in New Delhi had told me at that time that their force tried to stop Bhindranwale at each of their check posts but he received instructions from the home minister's office to let Bhindranwale pass unhindered. As Bhindranwale left in a great hurry, carefully maintained transcripts of all his sermons were left behind. They were reportedly set on fire in anger by the raiding Punjab police party.